Part 4 Summary

Part 3 found that companies' stated values and formal disclosures were only modestly aligned. In this section, I wanted to investigate why this might be the case by examining how the emphasis on corporate values changed between About Us pages and proxy statements from 2016 to 2024.

Approach: For each company-year with both documents available, I recorded whether each of the ten themes appeared on the About Us page and whether it was discussed in at least 1% of the proxy statement's sentences. This allowed me to compare the percentage of companies discussing each theme across the two sources.

I then examined how these differences changed over time, tested whether the changes were statistically significant, and repeated the analysis using different thresholds and across sectors.

Theme	Main Finding
Sustainability	Became substantially more common in proxy statements than on About Us pages
Innovation	Remained more prominent on websites, but the difference narrowed over time
Diversity and Inclusion	Increased in both sources, although website mentions declined after 2022
Safety	Increased at similar rates across both sources

Key Findings: Sustainability showed the clearest change. Between 2016–2018 and 2022–2024, the share of companies discussing sustainability in proxy statements increased from 38% to 95%, while website mentions rose only slightly. Innovation also became more common in proxy statements, narrowing the difference between the two sources.

Diversity and inclusion increased in both documents, but website mentions peaked around 2021–2022 before declining to 38% by 2024. This decline was not reflected in proxy statements. Safety, integrity, and performance generally followed similar trends across both sources. The sustainability shift was particularly noticeable in Consumer Discretionary and Healthcare, while Energy companies already emphasized sustainability in both documents.

Interpreting the Results: These findings suggest that public messaging and formal disclosures do not always evolve together. Sustainability, for example, became increasingly prominent in proxy statements without a comparable increase in public messaging. This pattern is consistent with the possibility that investor and regulatory expectations influence formal disclosures differently from corporate websites.

The results also help explain the modest alignment observed in Part 3, as companies may emphasize different priorities depending on the audience and purpose of the document.

Limitations: The two sources use different methods to identify themes, which makes changes over time more reliable than direct comparisons of their levels. Earlier years also contain fewer observations, and some proxy keywords may capture unrelated language. Finally, these findings identify patterns in corporate communication rather than establishing what caused them.